

Apple is financing the refresh

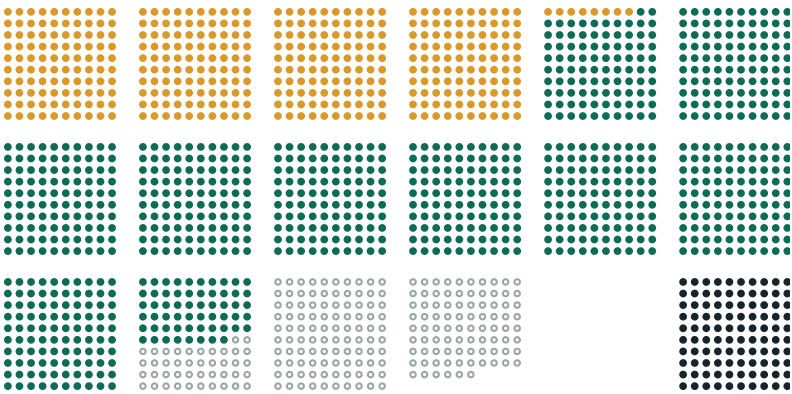
Signal Beaumont Independent School District in Texas is replacing its Chromebooks with 14,585 Apple laptops and iPads on an \$11.19 million, four-year lease, at 0% interest on the laptops.

Read Apple won on the four-year math. It paid for the 0% financing and offered a laptop expected to resell for \$180 to \$250, against \$10 for a worn-out Chromebook, just as memory costs pushed Chromebook prices up. That makes this a refresh win in a district forced to replace, and a market shift only if districts that are not due to replace start switching too.

Researched October 2, 2026. Tags in the left margin: Signal is the event, Fact is sourced, Read is our inference, Est is computed.

How big is 14,585 devices?

Each dot is 10 students. Sixteen blocks of 100 dots is the district's whole enrollment of 15,862. The last block on the right is the teachers.

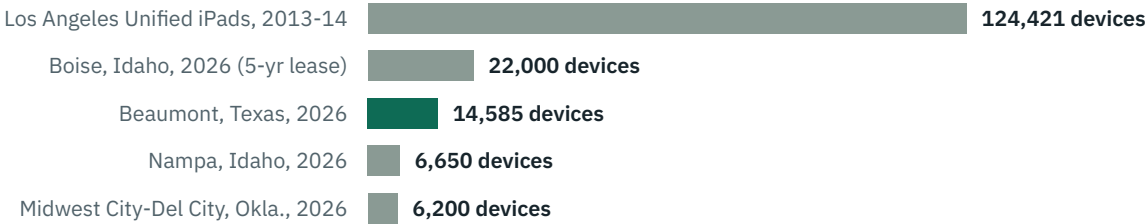


● iPad, pre-K to 2 ● Neo, grades 3 to 12 ○ no new device ● teachers

86%

of the district's students get a new Apple device, plus every teacher. Apple's school laptop launched in March 2026. Six months later it is outfitting a whole district.

Against other school device deals



"The PCs, believe it or not, are now significantly more expensive than an Apple Neo."

Cortney Stauffer, Assistant Superintendent of Operations, Nampa School District, Idaho, on its switch from Windows laptops. Idaho Education News, September 17, 2026.

How 86% was computed

9,500 student laptops + 4,085 iPads = 13,585 student devices / 15,862 students enrolled, 2026 = 86% plus 1,000 for teachers

Who else is doing this

District	Devices	Value	Term	Replaced	The read
Beaumont, Tex.	14,585 Neos and iPads	\$11.19M	4-yr lease, 0% / 0.99%	Chromebooks	\$767 a device, service and financing in
Boise, Idaho	~22,000 Neos, Airs, iPads	~\$18.2M	5-yr lease	Chromebooks, HP	Locked \$494 a laptop before the price rise
Nampa, Idaho	6,650 Neos and Airs	\$5.6M	4-yr lease	HP Windows	"PCs are now more expensive than a Neo"
Peninsula, Wash.	~8,000 students	~\$4.8M	4-yr lease, 1.7%	Chromebooks	Could pay cash. Kept reserves earning interest
Kansas City, Mo.	4,500+ Neos now	Not disclosed	Not disclosed	Windows, Chromebooks	30,000 devices to switch over time
Pinellas, Fla.	25,000 students	Not disclosed	Not disclosed	Windows	Named only by Apple. No local record found
New York City	350,000 Dell Chromebooks	\$129M devices	4 yr	Older Chromebooks	The other direction, 2025. Internet add-on since cancelled

Per device over the term: \$600 to \$842 across the Apple leases. Apple says about half of its large school laptop deals last quarter displaced Windows or Chromebooks. It gave no count.

What it looks like for a smaller buyer

One person	0% for 12 months on an Apple Card. Credit approval required.
Small business	12 to 48 months through outside lenders. No 0% advertised. "Not all applicants will qualify."
Any public school district	Up to 4 years, "as low as 0%." No published minimum: a district borrowing \$137,725 got 0%. A clause lets it walk away at year end without penalty.
Large district	Same paperwork. Size buys the unit price, such as Boise's \$494 locked before the June increase.

0%

advertised. The lease paper shows a 4.95% yield. Apple pays the gap up front

\$0.6-1.0M

what that 0% is worth on Beaumont's lease, against Lenovo's 4% (Est)

4 years

longest school term on offer

All of it

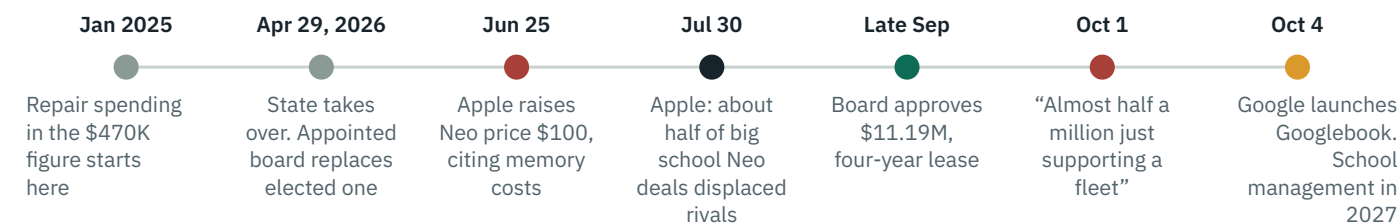
what a district loses if it walks: the devices and every payment made

What's not being said

Jun 25, 2026	The \$499 school price in the coverage is out of date. Apple raised it to \$599 in June. Beaumont has not disclosed what it pays per device.
Jul 30, 2026	Apple's "about half" has no base number. One of its three named examples mostly replaced iPads, not Chromebooks.
Oct 2, 2026	"Lowest four-year cost," but no rival bid totals were published. The edge was 0% against Lenovo's 4%, plus a resale value that is an estimate, not a guarantee.

Half a million, mostly not repairs

Beaumont's case, as the record shows it. The Texas Education Agency (TEA), the state school regulator, took over the district in April and appointed the board that voted.



Fact Of the \$469,576 cited, repairs were \$212,574. Staff time was \$220,040 and overtime \$36,962. Reports disagree on whether it covers one year or January 2025 onward. The fleet averages over five years old, and two-thirds is past its planned life.

Read The fleet wore out. The platform was not the cause. Staff time is only saved if staff leave, so the cash case is narrower than the quote. Apple won on financing and resale, and that is the part a rival can match.

The last time schools switched

Fact In 2014, the two national testing groups certified Chromebooks for online state tests, so every district needed keyboards at once. A \$199 Chromebook beat a \$379 iPad. Chromebooks passed iPads in US school shipments that fall. By 2016 Chrome held 58% of US school devices and Apple fell to 19%, from 25% a year earlier.

Where it breaks: That switch went to the cheaper device under a deadline. This one goes upmarket with no deadline, and Google's classroom software runs on a Mac either way.

Who gains, who carries

Gains

Apple: Mac revenue \$10.4B last quarter, up 29%, with the school laptop named as a driver.

Beaumont: a new fleet at about \$192 a device per year, repairs included.

Carries

Apple: the financing cost, about \$0.6-1.0M on this deal (Est).

The district: the resale risk, and 2030 prices when the lease ends.

Lenovo and Asus: a lost 14,600-unit order.

The caveat

If districts with working Chromebooks start switching, this becomes a market shift. If Google prices a cheap school Googlebook, it stalls.

For an executive

- What does each device cost us per year, including support, financing and resale?
- How much of the resale value in our plan is contracted, and how much is estimated?
- What is the vendor's 0% worth in dollars against our own cost of money?
- What share of our fleet is past its planned life today?
- How many staff hours a year go to keeping old devices running?

What to watch

- Oct 4, 2026** Google's Googlebook launch: is there a school model and price?
- Oct 29, 2026** Apple earnings (projected): does the "about half" claim come back with a count?
- Jan 26-29, 2027** FETC, the national school technology conference: pricing moves by either side
- Feb-Mar 2027** Spring school budget votes: do districts that aren't due to replace switch anyway?

Researched by NodeJ Deep Research. Every figure traces to a companion report with a source link on each number. For the full report, or a brief on a signal in your industry: julian@nodej.ai